



Unexpected Comedies

1-5 December 2025

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Welcome



The end of the semester is near, and with it come exams and projects of all kinds. Smushed between a world of studies and struggles, a twist of comedy is lways welcome! This program I created is filled with all kinds of serious setups that wind up spinning comedic twists all throughout the films, whether it be through body language, production, writing, or simply over-the-top action. So no matter the subject you’re studying for, I hope that within these pages, you’ll find a film that you find interesting.

Richard Karunia, Festival Director and Curator

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What's this program about?

History

The first comedies have existed since 425 BCE performed live in ancient Greek amphitheatres. Since then, the genre has evolved into a plethora of different forms, all exploring the concept of benign violation – a subverting of expectations. Though modern comedies tend to possess structure-like qualities, equipped with setups and punchlines, the 19th century introduced the world to surreal and “unexpected” comedies that emerged from the evocation of jarring and often illogical scenes.

Why Comedy?

According to Lauren Feldman, associate professor at Rutgers School of Communication and Information, comedy can play an important role in challenging people to address critical social issues.

People often incorrectly assume that comedy – because it is funny and entertaining – is inappropriate for communicating about serious issues, or that it can serve as a distraction from important problems. Comedy can, through its effects on audiences, help contribute to social change by drawing attention, disarming audiences, lowering resistance to persuasion, breaking down social barriers and stimulating sharing and discussion. And that is precisely the comedies this curation offers.



辣手神探

Hard Boiled

John Woo, 1992

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Regal Atlantic Station

Hard Boiled (1992) is not only John Woo's most thunderous action opera, but also one of his slyly funniest. Its comedy emerges from sheer excess: gunfights so prolonged and balletic they loop back into absurdity, bodies flying through glass with cartoon persistence, and explosions that feel proudly impossible. With a specially designed hospital that was constantly being destroyed, the crew had to shoot in chronological order; since when a wall explodes, it's gone for good. Complete with a baby covered in blood, the surreal mood Woo creates in *Hard Boiled* is supremely unique and strangely comedic.



Face/Off (1997) is John Woo at his most gloriously unhinged. An action melodrama so earnestly excessive it drifts into surreal comedy. The film's wildest laughs come not from jokes, but from performance absurdity: Nicolas Cage and John Travolta devouring each other's personas with operatic commitment, turning grief, rage, and revenge into a kind of identity slapstick. Facial expressions become punchlines, doves become punctuation, and every emotion is pushed past realism into mythic camp. Yet Woo plays it completely straight, which is exactly why it works. Fun production fact: Cage and Travolta spent weeks studying each other's physical movements and vocal rhythms, even recording tapes, so their "swapped" performances would mirror one another as precisely as possible. The result is both ridiculous and unforgettable.

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Face / Off

John Woo, 1997

좋은놈, 나쁜놈, 이상한놈

The Good, the Bad, the Weird

Kim Jee-woon, 2008



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Filmed physically in the Mongolian desert practically without CGI, *The Good, the Bad, the Weird* (2008) is Kim Jee-woon's delirious, self-aware remix of the spaghetti western, played at the velocity of a live-action cartoon. It charges across the Manchurian desert with slapstick propulsion—horse chases staged like Looney Tunes set pieces, gunfights that feel elastic rather than lethal, and action so exaggerated it becomes its own punchline. Its surreal comedy lies in how straight-facedly the film commits to absurdity. Becoming an amalgamation of impossible escapes, the villains' operatic menace, and a world where physics is more of a suggestion than a rule.

Inglourious Basterds (2009) is Quentin Tarantino's war movie as revisionist fairy tale, where history bends to the logic of cinema and violence becomes both horrific and absurd. Its unexpected comedy arises not from punchlines but from tonal dissonance: the grotesque theatricality of the Basterds, the cartoonish glee in their brutality, and the way genocide-era tension coexists with deadpan jokes, pipe-smoking monologues, and petty vanity. Even horror is played with a surreal wink, especially in Hans Landa's silky, almost playful menace. Fun production fact: Christoph Waltz nearly wasn't cast because Tarantino feared he'd never find someone who could speak all the required languages convincingly which were English, German, French, and Italian, until Waltz walked in and solved the movie. The result is a film that is at once chilling, funny, and perversely triumphant.

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Inglourious Basterds

THE NEW FILM BY QUENTIN TARANTINO

Quentin Tarantino, 2009





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Jojo Rabbit

Taika Waititi, 2019

Jojo Rabbit (2019) is Taika Waititi's audacious anti-hate fable disguised as a child's wartime fantasy, where historical horror collides with absurdist, surreal comedy. Its strangest laughs emerge from the perspective gap between Jojo's indoctrinated imagination and the gentle reality pressing in on it—most memorably through Waititi's buffoonish, imaginary Hitler, a cartoon specter of fascism rendered ridiculous and petulant. The film finds humor in whimsy and anachronism without dulling its cruelty, letting comedy become a weapon of deflation rather than escape. Fun production fact: the shooting locations in the Czech Republic had to be digitally altered because modern European streets no longer resemble 1940s Germany, meaning whole skylines and backgrounds were subtly rebuilt to preserve the storybook illusion. The result is a film that is tender, funny, and quietly devastating.

The Banshees of Inisherin (2022) is Martin McDonagh's deceptively quaint tragedy, where pastoral beauty frames a feud so petty it curdles into existential farce. Its unexpected surreal comedy grows from understatement and repetition: deadpan conversations that spiral into madness, the solemn absurdity of self-imposed mutilation, and the way everyday stubbornness takes on mythic weight. The humor is eerie because it's rooted in ritual and inevitability, not punchlines—laughter catches in your throat as often as it escapes. The film was shot on the remote Irish islands of Inis Mór and Achill, and Barry Keoghan's beloved donkey "Jenny" was played by a real local animal who became a minor on-set celebrity. The result is bleak, hilarious, and hauntingly absurd.

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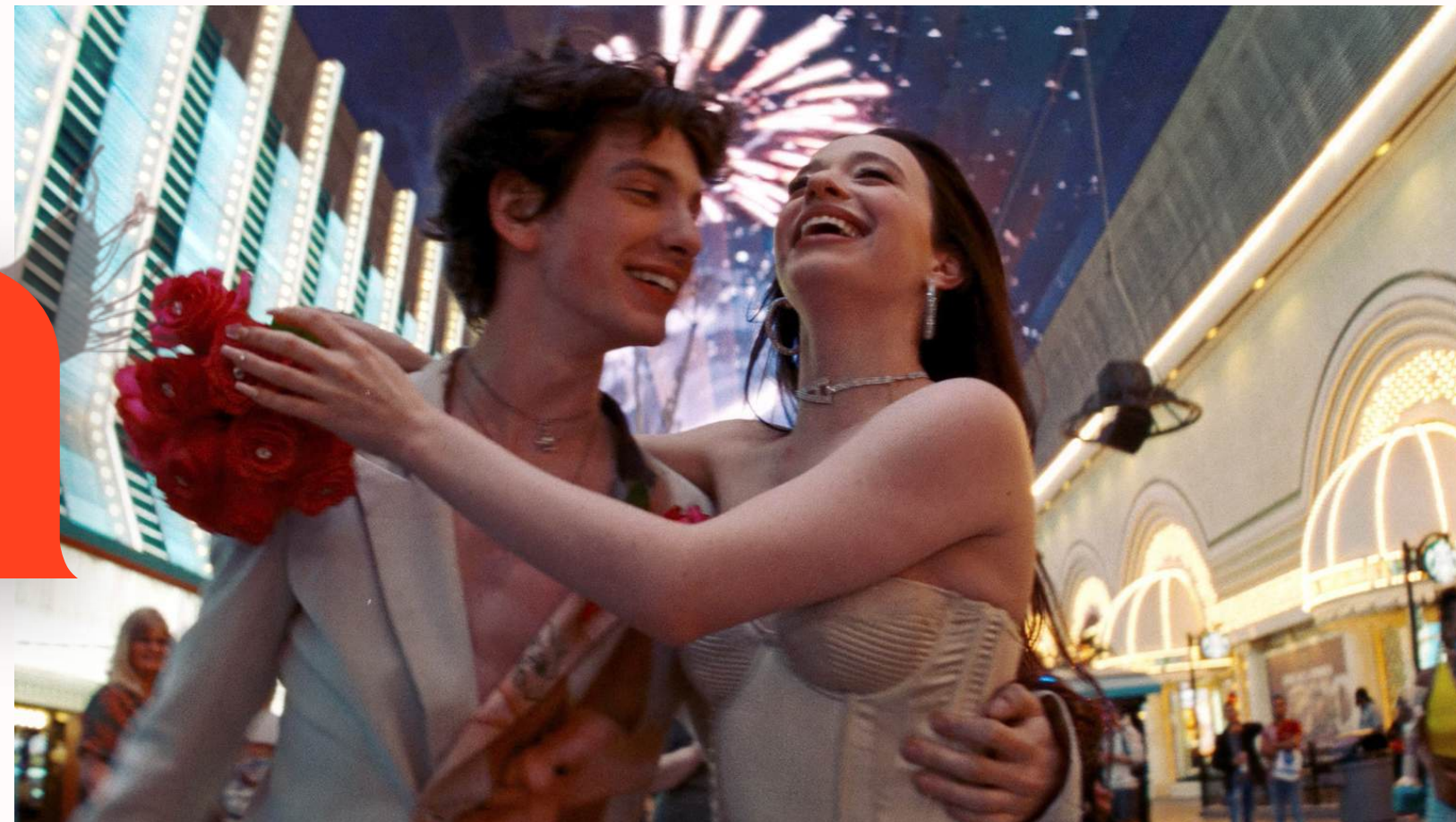
The Banshees of Inisherin

Martin McDonagh, 2022



Anora

Sean Baker, 2022



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Shot in real-life locations in Brighton, often with non-professional background players, *Anora* (2024) is Sean Baker's breathless, candy-colored descent into romantic fantasy and class nightmare, where fairy-tale excess curdles into farce. Its unexpected surreal comedy erupts from tonal whiplash where champagne dreams collapse into bureaucratic hellscape, cartoonishly wealthy villains barge into cramped Brooklyn rooms, and emotional pivots so abrupt they feel almost hallucinatory. Laughter comes unexpectedly from the pity and struggle of likely underpaid bodyguards who must drag spoiled young adults around. Baker treats chaos with screwball velocity while never losing the ache beneath the absurdity.

After nearly 20 years in the making, *No Other Choice* (2025) is Park Chan-wook's most perversely playful thriller, a film that turns middle-class desperation into a surreal engine of dark comedy. Its humor springs from the mismatch between lethal intent and absurd execution: meticulously planned violence undone by petty mishaps, corporate rituals that feel more grotesque than the crimes themselves, and a hero whose escalating moral collapse plays like a deadpan nightmare farce. Park treats murder with the icy precision of satire, letting the comedy emerge from repetition, futility, and humiliating logistics rather than punchlines.

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No Other Choice

Park Chan-wook, 2025

